

CHAPTER ONE

PART ONE

According to the brief history of my father (as told to my sister, Ila Rose, by my father's half-sister, Mary Anderson) he owned a homestead in the Lone Pine country twenty miles east of Idaho Falls. The family stayed on this homestead following Loverna's birth in 1916, until they got their deed and then they moved to Idaho Falls. This was probably around 1917 because I remember my Mother telling me of the flu epidemic in 1918 that was so devastating and that the family lived in the house at 20th and Emerson during this epidemic and it was in this house that Ila Rose, myself, and my brother, Martin, were born (the latter, on September 11, 1924). I recall very little about the first four years of my life and never knew any of my grandparents. The only one living at the time of my birth was Maryette RICE (HARRIS) STANDLEY, my father's mother, who had divorced my grandfather, Solomon Webster Harris, and remarried. She lived in Logan, Utah and died there on May 28, 1924 shortly after my second birthday. Of my early years in Idaho Falls I seem only to recall deep snow, cold weather and being afraid of a big, black dog.

Sometime during this early period, my Dad fell off the roof of our house and because of it and other problems developed quite poor health. This must have affected his work situation and as a consequence the family decided to move to Mesa, Arizona. This move took place about the middle of May, 1926. We have a photograph of the family taken in Tooele, Utah with members of my Mother's family in May 1926 enroute to Arizona. My own recollection of this period is, of course, very dim. I vaguely remember our being stopped as we entered Arizona and having to eat or dump out any of the fruits, vegetables or honey which we had brought along for our sustenance. This because of Arizona's very strick anti-bug laws which are still in existence.

After our arrival in Arizona, we stayed at some campground for an indeterminate period of time. I recall my sister, LoVerna, being stung by a scorpion while we were there. The Arizona Temple of the Church was under construction at this time and I suppose that is one of the principle reasons why we came to Arizona, i.e so that my father would have some employment. At least I know that he did work on the Temple, principally in the landscaping field, because his occupation is listed as a gardener on my school records in Arizona. My memories of my father are very vague, of course, but I seem to recall going on some Fathers' and Sons outings with him and my brothers. My brother, Richard, was ten years older than I, so I do remember his being around when I was a child.

In October 1927 the Arizona Temple was dedicated. We have several photographs of this occasion. One being a photo of the General Authorities of the Church who were present as well as other dignitaries. According to a recent reconstruction of information on the occasion of the sixtieth anniversary of the Temple's dedication, the following people have been identified in the photograph: Pres. Heber J. Grant and his counselors, Anthony W. Ivins and David O. McKay, George Albert Smith, John F. Widtsoe, Richard R. Lyman, Rudger Clawson, Joseph Fielding Smith, J. Golden Kimball, Sylvester Q. Cannon, George F. Richards, Stephen L. Richards, and Spencer W. Kimball. There probably were others but it is difficult to identify them in the photo. There is also a photograph of many of the children who were present on that occasion. Members of our family who can be identified are Loverna, Ila Rose, Martin and myself (at age five very tow-headed).

It was also in 1927 that Charles Lindbergh flew non-stop in the Spirit of St. Louis from New York to Paris, the first such flight across the Atlantic Ocean. He became an instant hero but suffered some tragic things during his life including the kidnapping and murder of his infant son.

In 1928 I started school (first grade) at the Lincoln school in Mesa, Arizona. This school was located on West First Avenue and as of 1977 was still being used as a records repository by the Mesa school system. Sometime during this period of my life one of the neighborhood children died of spinal meningitis. I didn't know what it was but there was certainly a lot of fear and concern in the area. Our family was very poor since my father apparently didn't earn very much working as a gardener at the Temple.

There is very little that I recollect about this period of time in Mesa. There was a little black kid who was a friend of mine and he would always come to our house and ask my mother if "Vigil could come out and play". To this day I'm known as Uncle Vigil to some of the children of friends of ours who have heard this story. There was one incident which remains in my memory and that is of coming home from school one day and crossing through what must have been a cotton gin area. The friend with me decided to cut through an area which was kind of white and it turned out to be hot ashes. By the time he got on the other side he was screaming bloody murder and the skin on his feet was peeling off. We apparently did some work in the cotton fields since I have some pictures of Martin and me sitting amongst the cotton and because of our towheads you could hardly see us. We also had experiences in "stealing" watermelons with the older kids. My brother Richard delivered newspapers and one day got hit by a car and suffered a broken leg. It was years later that a cousin Nathan (I think Nathan Harris) in

Utah was able to obtain some settlement for this accident but he managed to make off with most of the money much to my poor mother's consternation. I don't think that she ever trusted a lawyer again.

My father died in 1929 (February 5) after being ill quite a bit of the time previously. I recall of having gone to the store with Martin and Ila Rose to buy some penny candy and someone coming to tell us that our Dad was dying. We arrived to find my mother kneeling and crying at his bedside and I suppose that he had already passed away or did so soon afterward. The period after his death is fuzzy. He was buried at the Mesa City cemetery and I recall vividly of the casket being lowered and the workmen throwing dirt in on top of it.

1929 was the year of the traumatic crash of the stock market on October 29, 1929 which initiated a world wide depression in the following year. Ironically, a Republican president was elected, Herbert Hoover, and he has been faulted as being the cause of the depression, but in the light of history the most influential factor beside the crash of the stock market was the passing of a trade restrictive bill called the Smoot-Hawley Act. The Smoot was Reed Smoot, a member of the quorum of the twelve and the first Senator elected from the State of Utah.

I continued in school for the 1929-1930 school year (the second grade). We lived on Morris Ave. and were members of the Third Ward of the LDS church. I don't know why we stayed in Arizona but I imagine it had something to do with my siblings schooling or the insurance from my Dad's policy (the grand sum of \$1000.00). Sometime later we bought a Willys-Knight touring car with some of the money so that we could return to Idaho Falls.

We still owned the house on 20th and Emerson which was occupied by my Uncle Solomon R. Harris (Dad's brother) and his wife Aunt Sarah. We probably stayed in Mesa until after school was out in June of 1930 because I was baptized on April 5, 1930 in the font of the Mesa temple and was confirmed the next day April 6 which was the centennial of the official founding of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter Day Saints. I was baptized by Alfred H. Nichols and confirmed by Frank T. Pomeroy.

PART TWO

Shortly after the school year ended we started our journey for Idaho Falls. There wasn't much of a road and I seem to recall having to drive around quicksand areas in the road. In addition to members of our family there was another man who traveled with us apparently to help out with the driving and he must have been some kind of a con man because

after we got to Idaho Falls, he ended up with the car. One of the memories I have of this trip is of stopping one night and sleeping upon some old springs on a bedstead on top of one of the tall mesas occupied by Indians. We had to climb up on rope ladders to get to the top of the mesa. I recall that my Mother was very frightened of the Indians probably for no other reason than innate prejudice from wild stories she had heard all of her life. I also remember of stopping in a forested area at a service station and drinking out of an old rain barrel (the water tasted of gasoline). This must have been at Jacob's Lake in the Kaibab forest in northern Arizona.

After our return to Idaho Falls, Idaho we shared the house at 20th and Emerson, still owned by my Mother, with my Uncle Sol and Aunt Sarah and their adopted son, Clifford. We lived at this house for a couple of years and I attended the Eastside grammar school for my third and fourth grades. I must have been somewhat of a pugnacious child since I remember fighting other kids quite a bit over marble games and my brother, Richard, coming to my rescue on one occasion. Apparently I learned to swim during this period as well. I recall being in a canoe with Richard and it capsizing in the canal and his telling me to swim for shore since he had to save the canoe. By this time Uncle Sol and Aunt Sarah had a little place of their own.

These were the depression years, the very deep depression years and we were fortunate in having a plot of ground on which we could raise much of our food. The kids all had to work to plant and harvest what we grew. We sold small bottles of ground-up horseradish which was pretty powerful. The area where we lived was known as "poverty flats" so one can imagine generally what the neighborhood was like. My mother always insisted in keeping a good house, she said there was no use in being dirty just because we were poor. This was a product of her Swiss heritage, although she was only about six years old when she left her homeland.

Apparently, after some members of the Nageli family joined the Church, they planned to all move to the United States. For reasons best known to them, my mother was sent on ahead with a missionary couple who brought her to Logan, Utah. She lived in various foster homes until she got married to my father. She was about 21 years old before she saw any of her family again and that was because of a chance encounter at a General Conference of the Church in Salt Lake City. Three of her sisters and a brother had come to the U.S. and had endeavoured to find her but with no success.

My brother, Richard, joined the U. S. Army shortly after we returned to Idaho. Having graduated from High School and being in the midst of the depression, it was

impossible to find work so the army offered the best opportunity for him. After his basic training he was sent to the Philippine Islands and we only saw him on one occasion after that when he returned for a visit with a girl he had married after his tour of duty with the Army was finished.

About this time I had my tonsils and adenoids removed. For months, maybe even a year, I had suffered with boils and abscesses in my neck and chin which had to be lanced periodically. I think I was about ten years old at the time and I recall the nurse administering the anesthetic (ether) calling me a "nice little lady". I threatened to burn the hospital down as I was coming out from under the anesthetic. One summer about this same period of time, I went to visit my Uncle Henry and Aunt Lucy Guyaz, who lived in Salmon, Idaho. It was quite an interesting adventure. On one occasion the salmon were swimming up-stream to spawn and at the confluence of the Salmon and Limhi Rivers, the stream was literally black with salmon. My Uncle Henry and others simply speared the salmon in the shallow waters. I don't really know how large they were but some appeared to be as tall as I was. They were steamed and canned for food supply.

Sometime in 1932 (probably the summer) we moved from our home at 20th and Emerson to 308 J St. on the west side of town. We had attempted to do something with our property at 20th and Emerson but it was too much for Mother and her young family, particularly with Richard gone. By this time Uncle Sol and Aunt Sarah had moved and although Uncle Sol tried to help us, Mother found a job working at the LDS Hospital which was located near the Snake River on the other side of town and it was a very long walk for her. She traded the Emerson property for a little three room house on J Street, getting the worst of the deal but it was easy for someone to take advantage of a widow with four children in desperate financial straits.

The house on J St. was just barely adequate for us. It had a large kitchen area with a coal-fired stove which for a long time was the only heat in the house. There was a front room (which doubled as a bedroom for Martin and me with a fold-down bed) and a bedroom for Mother, Loverna and Ila Rose. For a long time we had only an outside privy but eventually were able to have an inside toilet installed. There was still no bathtub and until I graduated from High School, we bathed in a galvanized tub with water heated in the reservoir of the coal stove.

Below the back porch was a small cellar where we kept coal, potatoes and any food we wanted to keep cool. We had no ice box or refrigerator. Somewhere along the line we got

a space heater for the living room but you can imagine how cold it would get in the house in Idaho's sometime 35 degrees below winters. Heated bricks wrapped in towels and tucked into beds made them tolerable to jump into on a cold winter's night.

Of necessity, we raised a garden and kept some chickens on this plot. During the Depression years (1932-1940) things like Thanksgiving dinner consisted of killing a couple of our own chickens by chopping off their heads and eating the produce from our own garden. Sometimes the eating was pretty lean. I never recall of having a turkey during these years. Christmas and birthdays were always observed but with meager gifts. My mother always worked hard to make sure that we had something and, being a very proud and independent woman, didn't subscribe to taking charity. Mother, however, was always willing to share with the more unfortunate. We lived quite close to the railroad tracks and this resulted in our receiving frequent calls from those persons who were riding the rails in the U.S. to try to find something somewhere to keep body and soul together. We never handed out anything to a person who wouldn't at least chop some wood or hoe in the garden but if they were willing to do this (and most would) they would be able to share our humble meal with us sitting at the very same table.

I started to become more politically aware of things beginning with the elections of 1932 with Hoover running against Franklin D. Roosevelt. I'm not sure why but my Mother was staunchly in favor of Hoover although he was blamed for the depression under which we suffered so much. However, after Roosevelt was elected, I wrote a letter to him asking him if there wasn't something he could do for widows with children to support. I got an answer back from his staff chief explaining some of the programs that the administration had in mind. I was quite a hero at the Riverside school and the teacher read the letter that I received to the whole class. 1932 was the first of four elections won by Franklin D. Roosevelt and I grew up from childhood to my years in the Navy with Roosevelt as president. One of his sons, John, was a young officer on board the U.S.S. Wasp the same time as I was a crew member.

In 1933 Hitler became Chancellor of Germany and the infamous Reichstag fire gave him an excuse to acquire dictatorial powers. I recall this incident and remember the concern my mother expressed at this occurring so close to her native land of Switzerland. During this year the United States, after sixteen years, re-established diplomatic relations with the USSR. I recall reading about the debates in Congress over this issue. This also was the year that the 18th amendment to the Constitution was repealed with the

State of Utah being the final state to approve this repeal of the prohibition of the making, importing, sale etc, of alcoholic beverages in the United States. It was repealed because it was essentially unenforceable and led to the great crime kings, such as Al Capone, and the era of the speak-easies.

My early youth recreation consisted of swimming, fishing, going on scout camps in the summer and iceskating during the winter, usually on the forebay of the Snake River approximately where the Idaho Falls temple is now located. We frequently had some exciting times in the early spring when we stretched our ice-skating too long and had to scamper for safety from breaking ice. We also did some skiing on the snow which had accumulated on the sand hills overlooking the river. When I grew a little older I used to go hunting for jackrabbits which abounded in the area outside of Idaho Falls.

During my teen-age years, the 4th Ward chapel was constructed a few block from where we lived. I did some work on it as well as helping to dig the sand down to the bedrock lava for the foundation of the Idaho Falls temple. This temple is constructed on the site of our old sand hill where we did our sledding and skiing. The hill also had lots of small caves in it which made for good hiding places when one decided to run away from home "for awhile." As I mentioned above Richard had gone to the Philippines with the U. S. Army and stayed there when he finished his tour. He joined the U. S. Customs office and was married in November 1934 to Maria del Carmen Stevens, a catholic girl, whom he met in the Islands. This just about broke Mother's heart since Richard was her first born and she had expected so much of him. He and Carmen came to visit with us for awhile. I'm not sure of the exact date but it possibly was in the winter of 1934/1935 or a year later. I recall going to the railroad station in Idaho Falls with my sled to pick up their suitcases. Of course, we had no car, very few people did in those days and never thought much of walking fairly long distances.

Our experience of having Richard and Carmen live with us was very traumatic and nearly killed my mother. Carmen was from a well-to-do family which had its antecedents back to the Spanish American War. She didn't take kindly to suddenly being thrust upon a family which was always on the verge of poverty. She was also a Catholic through and through and their stay was rather tempestuous. We turned over our front room to them and the rest of the family lived in the other two rooms of our small house. I remember Carmen making a special dish (I suppose it was a souffle or omelette) which used a whole dozen eggs, more than we ordinarily used in a month and my mother nearly had a fit.

Our usual diet was much more modest - lots of potatoes, bread and gravy and bread and milk. Eventually, Carmen prevailed upon Richard to return to the Philippines. I don't know how long they stayed but we never saw Richard again although we did get letters from him. Apparently he and Carmen had a child, Anthony, who along with his mother was interned by the Japanese until after the end of the war. Since Richard was a casualty we heard from some military officer who knew them that Carmen remarried.